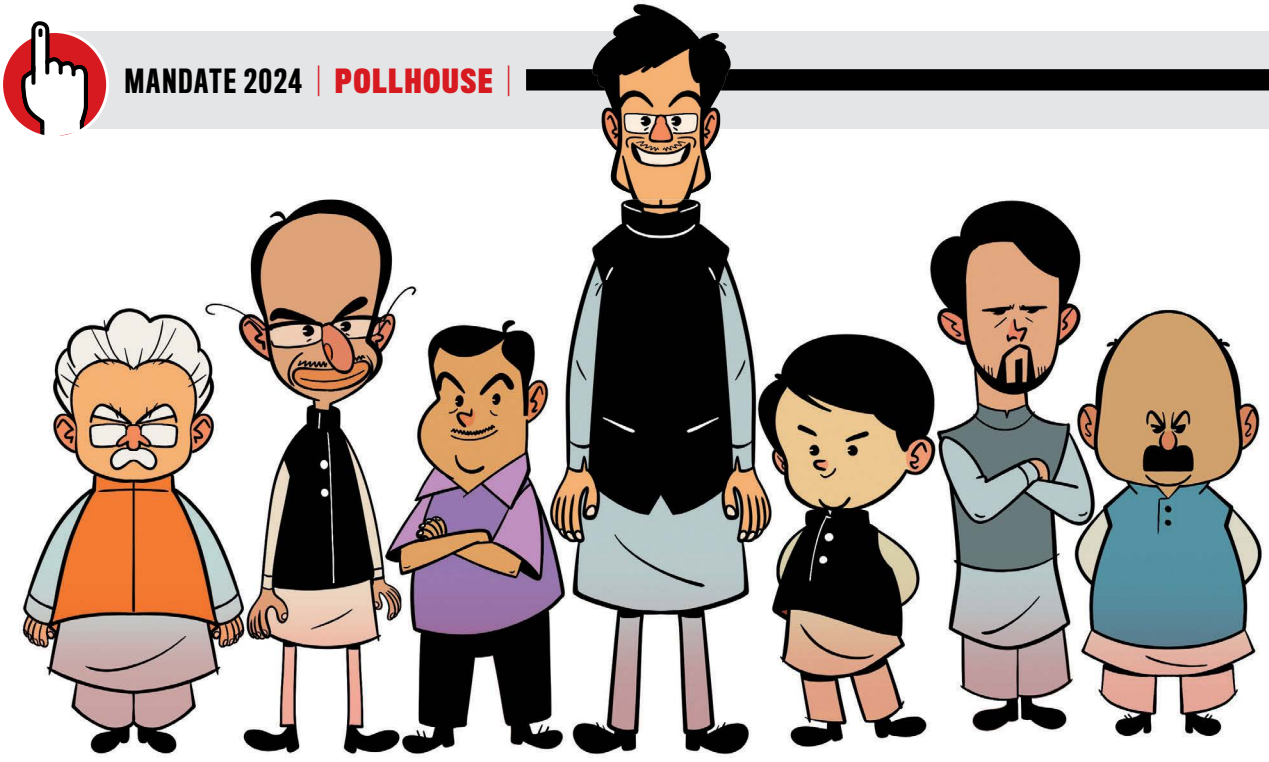
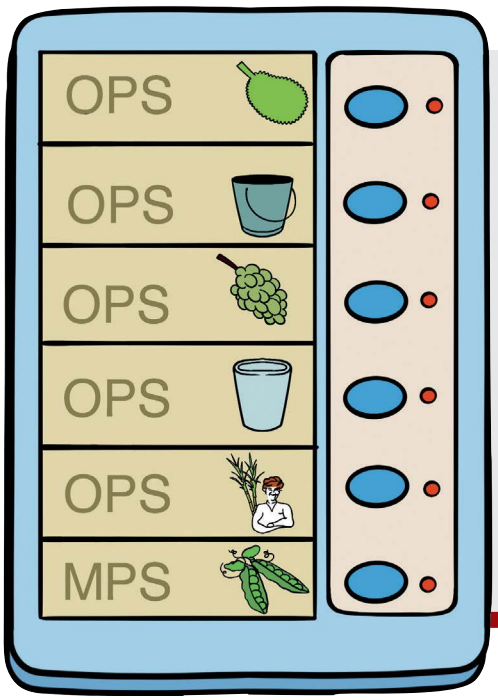


MAHARATHIS @MAHABHARATA

For all the Opposition's giant-killing ambitions, expressed in high moral tones from the stage, their actions don't quite match up to stated intent. The big whales seem afraid of the waters! Modi's army, by contrast, is staging a full cannonball run—with all its armoured tanks and howitzers sent to raise heat and dust on the battlefield. With even Rajya Sabha MPs dispatched to the frontlines, its cavalry boasts a phalanx of Union ministers and former chief ministers. Shivraj Singh Chouhan, coaxed out of his soft sulk, is back to doing what he's best at—working the crowds at his old staging post, Vidisha. Manohar Lal Khattar has hit the Grand Trunk Road to Karnal. Basavaraj Bommai is out to soothe himself with the choicest cardamom garland from Haveri. Nitin Gadkari did not lose his way home on some tricky clover-leaf flyover of politics, as some speculated, and Nagpur hosts its favourite son. Jyotiraditya Scindia's regal palanquin aims to expel



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▶ TAMIL NADU

THE LONE THEVAR WITH FIVE SHADOWS

Cast adrift from his lifelong alma mater, Ottakaratheevar Panneerselvam can be pardoned for feeling a little befuddled these days. There was a time when his reverential proximity to the late AIADMK prima donna J. Jayalalithaa had earned him 15 months, in three instalments, as ad hoc Tamil Nadu chief minister. Fallen from that paradise after a 2022 expulsion, he's eyeing the Ramanathapuram seat as an independent, with some friendly BJP backing. A draw of lots was held for his choices from among available symbols, and he got 'Jackfruit' instead of 'Bucket' or 'Grapes'.